

POLITICAL PHILOSOPHER Born 1818 Died 1883

Karl Marx

“The history of all... society is the history of **class struggle**.”

KARL MARX, FROM “THE COMMUNIST MANIFESTO,” 1848

Revolutionary socialist and philosopher Karl Marx was born into a well-to-do German Jewish family in Trier. His father had converted to Christianity to avoid persecution by the Prussian authorities. Karl was sent to university to become a lawyer like his father, but instead immersed himself in the study of philosophy and radical politics. Rebelling against his social origins, he became an atheist and a savage critic of the prosperous middle classes.

When Marx was a young man in the 1840s, Europe seemed to many people to be ripe for revolution. Marx became a political journalist, plunging energetically into arguments against the authorities and fellow radicals with whom he disagreed. At the same time, in unpublished manuscripts, he developed a complex philosophy of history, purporting to explain the

alienated state of humans in the modern world and to justify a future transformation of society.

Marx and Engels

In 1844 Marx formed a close friendship with Friedrich Engels, the son of a wealthy cotton-mill owner. Marx and Engels shared the belief that

Victorian patriarch

Despite his enthusiasm for violent revolution, Karl Marx, pictured here in 1875, was a gentle father and husband. He reserved an intellectual hatred for people with whose political views he disagreed.



Student days

In 1836, Marx enrolled as a law and philosophy student at the Friedrich Wilhelm University in Berlin (above), now called Humboldt University.

Forging friendships

Marx formed his lifelong friendship with Friedrich Engels (right in picture) in Paris in August 1844. The son of a German industrialist, with a business in Lancashire, England, Engels provided Marx with financial support as well as intellectual collaboration.

